

Salary negotiation basics

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Most entry-level candidates accept the first number offered, largely out of fear that negotiating will cost them the offer — but reasonable, well-researched negotiation rarely does, and even a modest increase compounds significantly over a career since future raises and jobs are often benchmarked off current pay. Negotiation for freshers looks different from experienced-hire negotiation: the room to move on base salary is often narrower (many campus offers are on a fixed band), but there is frequently more flexibility than candidates assume around joining bonuses, relocation support, or role/team placement. This sub-module covers researching a realistic market range before any conversation happens, how to handle the 'expected salary' question without anchoring yourself too low, concrete negotiation scripts, and how to recognize when an offer is genuinely fair versus when there's real room to negotiate further.

1. Researching Market Rate Before Negotiating

Negotiating without a researched reference point is negotiating blind — a candidate who doesn't know the typical range for a role, company tier, and location has no way to judge whether an offer is fair, generous, or low. Sources like Glassdoor, LinkedIn Salary, AmbitionBox, and direct conversations with recent graduates from the same college who joined similar companies give a usable range, even if imprecise. For campus placements specifically, the placement cell or seniors who interned/joined the same company in prior years are often the most accurate source, since they know the college's specific negotiated band with that employer.

2. When to Bring Up Salary

As a general rule, salary discussion is best deferred until later in the process — after there's a genuine offer or clear interest, not during the first interview round when there's nothing yet to negotiate around. Bringing it up too early can look like salary is the primary motivator rather than the role itself; deferring it too long (never asking at all before accepting) can mean losing the only real window to negotiate. If asked directly and early, giving a range rather than a hard number, or briefly deferring ('I'd like to learn more about the role first, but I'm flexible and open to discussing compensation once we're both sure it's a good fit') keeps the door open without dodging the question evasively.

3. Handling "What's Your Expected Salary?"

This question is genuinely tricky for freshers because anchoring too low leaves money on the table, while anchoring unrealistically high (without research) risks looking uninformed or pricing yourself out. The safer approach is citing a researched range rather than a single number, and tying it to market data rather than personal need: 'Based on what I've seen for similar roles at comparable companies, I'd expect somewhere in the range of X to Y, but I'm open to discussing based on the full compensation package.' This shows you've done homework without being either falsely modest or unrealistically aggressive.

- Weak answer: 'Whatever you think is fair' (gives away all negotiating position).
- Strong answer: 'From my research on similar roles at comparable companies, I'd expect somewhere around 6-7 LPA, though I'm flexible depending on the overall package and growth opportunities.'

4. Negotiating Beyond Base Salary

For campus and entry-level hiring specifically, base salary is often on a relatively fixed band set by HR policy, which means the more productive negotiation lever is frequently elsewhere: a joining bonus, relocation assistance, an earlier or later joining date to accommodate a personal need, a specific team or project placement, or a review timeline (e.g., asking about the first performance review cycle rather than the starting number). Framing a request around one of these non-base-salary levers is often both more realistic to grant and less likely to hit a rigid policy wall than pushing directly on the base number.

- Sample ask: 'I understand the base band is fixed for this role — is there any flexibility on the joining bonus or relocation support, given I'd be moving cities for this role?'

5. Sample Negotiation Scripts

Having a small set of tested phrases ready reduces the anxiety of negotiating live, especially for a first-time negotiation where the instinct is often to simply accept whatever is offered rather than risk the conversation feeling confrontational.

- Opening a negotiation politely: 'Thank you for the offer — I'm genuinely excited about this role. Based on my research on similar positions, I was hoping we could discuss the compensation a bit further.'
- Countering with a specific ask: 'Given the market range I've seen for this role, would it be possible to move the offer closer to X?'
- Responding to 'this is our final offer': 'I understand — thank you for clarifying. In that case, I'd like to accept, and I appreciate you considering my request.'

6. Recognizing a Fair Offer vs. Room to Push

Not every offer has room to negotiate, and pushing on an already-fair, band-locked campus offer can occasionally read poorly if done insistently. Signals that there's little further room include the recruiter explicitly stating the offer is fixed company-wide policy for the role level, or the offer already sitting at or above your researched range. Signals that there may be genuine room include a wide published range for the role with the offer at the low end, or a recruiter's

phrasing that leaves an opening ('This is our initial offer' rather than 'This is fixed').

7. Negotiating Without Risking the Offer

The overwhelming majority of professional negotiation conversations, conducted respectfully and based on research rather than an ultimatum, do not result in an offer being withdrawn — recruiters expect some negotiation and budget for it. The behaviors that do risk an offer are different from negotiating itself: issuing an ultimatum, misrepresenting a competing offer that doesn't exist, or negotiating in a hostile or entitled tone. A polite, research-backed, single round of negotiation — expressing genuine enthusiasm for the role alongside the ask — is standard professional behavior, not a risk.

Common Pitfalls

- Accepting the first number offered purely out of fear that any negotiation will cost the offer.
- Naming an expected salary with no market research behind it, either too low or unrealistically high.
- Bringing up salary in the very first interview round, before there's genuine mutual interest established.
- Fabricating a competing offer to create false leverage — a high-risk move if it's ever checked or questioned.
- Pushing hard on base salary when the real, more flexible lever was a joining bonus or relocation support.
- Negotiating with an ultimatum tone rather than an enthusiastic, collaborative one.
- Failing to ask about non-salary terms (review timeline, team placement) that are often more negotiable than base pay.

Key Takeaways

- Research a realistic market range (Glassdoor, LinkedIn Salary, seniors at the same company) before any negotiation conversation.
- Defer salary discussion until there's genuine mutual interest, not the very first interview round.
- Answer 'expected salary' with a researched range, not a single number and not 'whatever you think is fair.'
- For campus/entry-level offers, joining bonus, relocation, and role placement are often more flexible than the base band.
- A polite, research-backed negotiation is standard professional behavior and rarely puts an offer at risk.
- Know the difference between a genuinely fixed offer and one with real room — don't push on a clearly locked band.

Learn More

Harvard Business Review — 15 Rules for Negotiating a Job Offer

<https://hbr.org/2014/04/15-rules-for-negotiating-a-job-offer>

Indeed — How to Negotiate Salary After a Job Offer

<https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/pay-salary/how-to-negotiate-salary>

LinkedIn Learning Blog — Salary Negotiation Tips

<https://www.linkedin.com/business/talent/blog>